

facture 20,000-40,000 wafers a month, it will take five years. And we'll start with our own demand. **Semiconductor demand in India today is about \$40 billion and by 2030 it is estimated to cross \$100 billion, which is 10% of the global demand.** That will be our walking part of the journey getting into running. We will not take as much time to grow as TSMC or Samsung took, because we will learn from them. They were the first few pure-play foundries... There is no shame in partnering—JV is a very good strategy.

Q: What are your thoughts on AI given that there are concerns around job losses in India?

A: I am of the belief that technology has huge advantages. But we have to leverage technology for its disadvantages. When fossil fuel took centre stage, we saw that the environment was getting polluted, and then we worked on green energy. When we saw the by-product from crude oil, we started the manufacture of nylon fibre. We have always seen a circular economy. If you look at the advantages of AI, then the price to pay to address its disadvantages is peanuts.

42 | [Then], little surgeries that can be done through robotics can save lives of people in villages. If we build a framework to address the negatives of AI, we can enjoy the benefits—and the benefits are far bigger. For example, we all have natural intelligence. We have set up a system of police, judiciary, and laws—and those who don't follow this are punished. The same structure has to be done for AI. And it is happening; countries and companies have to participate and collaborate. I feel India plays a huge role here—with its huge population and democratic goals. **If there is a consortium planned for regulating AI, India can play a big role. It can be like the WHO, like a World AI Organisation.** We are preparing a proposal. We will take it to the G20 and to other countries that are partnering and participating with us.

Q: There's been a start-up funding winter. Do you think it's coming to an end?

A: [Bringing it] to an end is our responsibility. There is \$20 billion of dry powder available. But we need... deep tech start-ups where investors will invest. Our GDP is close to \$4 trillion now. China and the US together have a GDP of about \$40 trillion. I want to target that market. All this SaaS-based, retail-based [start-ups] are good, but I need deep tech [start-ups]. We are now seeing start-ups in deep tech, product, semiconductor IP and EV... The government is also working on enabling seed funds for start-ups. We have a Startup India Seed Fund, a fund of funds, a Startup India Investor Connect and a Credit Guarantee Scheme for Startups.



“People should not feel that investment in India is a black box.... [Investors] want to know the policies and I want to make it easy and transparent [for them]”

We are also working with incubators. We have also analysed patent data globally and there is an increase in patent filing by India. We are looking at companies and countries with which JVs can be formed. Our recent success has been in bringing together Argonne National Laboratory of the US and Smart Living Lab at IIIT Hyderabad for joint research on climate modelling in our cities and developing associated sensor capabilities. **We will do much more because we have to enable the dry powder to be leveraged for driving growth of not just India, [but] for the world. BT**

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